

TOPIC 8: PERSECUTION OF EARLY BELIEVERS (PART 2)

1. Saul's Persecution (Acts 8:1–3; 9:1–2)

After Stephen's death a great persecution arose against the church in Jerusalem. Believers were scattered through Judea and Samaria (except the apostles). Saul ravaged the church, entering houses and dragging off men and women to prison. He later sought letters to Damascus to arrest followers of the Way – showing the intensity of his opposition before his conversion.

2. Martyrdom of James (Acts 12:1–4)

King Herod (Agrippa I) laid violent hands on some of the church. He killed James the brother of John with the sword. When he saw that it pleased the Jews, he proceeded to arrest Peter also. The church responded with earnest prayer; God later delivered Peter.

3. Lessons

- Persecution can scatter believers and thereby spread the gospel (Acts 8:4).
- Even leaders (James) may face death for their faith.
- Prayer is the Church's response under threat.
- God can transform a persecutor (Saul) into an apostle – hope remains.

4. Summary

Saul's persecution scattered the church; James was martyred under Herod. Suffering was real, yet the word of God continued to advance and prayer sustained the believers.

End of Topic 8 – Persecution of Early Believers Part 2

— End of JSS 3 Christian Religious Studies First Term Notes —